KRISTA RECKER PROPERTIES

THE FIRST-TIME BUYER GUIDE

5 questions to ask before you buy *your first home.*

A short field guide for first-time buyers in Greater Boston. The questions inside are the ones that separate a great first home from a stressful one, and a confident offer from an expensive one.

Strategy first. Decisions backed by data.

BEFORE YOU START

The bank's number is *not your number.*

The first question most first-time buyers ask is "what can I afford." The first answer most lenders give is a number that lands on the high side of comfortable. The temptation is to take that number, find the nicest house that fits inside it, and write the offer. That sequence is how first-time buyers end up house poor, cash thin, and a little resentful of the home they were so excited about.

The first-time buyers I have watched land calmly in Greater Boston do not start with the maximum number. They start with what their life needs to keep working after the closing wire hits. The cash that needs to stay liquid. The monthly that leaves room. The offer discipline that does not get caught up in a Saturday open house bidding war. These are the five questions I walk every first-time buyer through before we even start looking at houses.

How to use this guide

Read all five. Try the exercise at the end of each one. Bring the answers, or the questions you cannot answer, to whoever you trust to help you decide. Or bring them to me on a 30 minute strategy session. There is no commitment to buy.

01

QUESTION ONE · THE FULL COST

What does owning actually cost, *beyond the mortgage payment*?

WHY IT MATTERS

Most first-time buyers map the cost of owning as the mortgage payment, full stop. That is the number that gets compared to rent. That is the number the lender quotes. That is the number the affordability calculators spit out. It is also the number that quietly understates the real cost of homeownership by a meaningful margin.

The real cost includes property taxes, homeowners insurance, condo or HOA fees if any, water and sewer, gas and electric for a building that is probably bigger or less efficient than your current rental, snow and yard care, and a monthly reserve for the maintenance that will eventually arrive. Roofs, water heaters, boilers, refrigerators, washing machines, and dishwashers all wear out on a schedule no one warns you about. The number that matters is the all-in monthly, not the mortgage.

TRY THIS

Write down every category of cost a homeowner has that a renter does not. Estimate the monthly. Add a reserve for ongoing maintenance based on the age and size of the home. The total is your real monthly to plan against.

02

QUESTION TWO · THE LIVING NUMBER

What can you borrow *that still lets the rest of your life work*?

WHY IT MATTERS

Lenders approve you for the maximum loan that fits their formulas. Their job is to lend, not to model your life. The number that comes back from pre-approval is usually higher than the number that leaves room for the things you actually care about. Travel. Retirement contributions. Childcare. The business idea you are still sitting with. A real emergency fund. The pre-approval is a ceiling, not a target.

The right number is the one that funds the life you actually want to live. The mortgage payment that lets you keep saving roughly the percentage of your income you save today. The price point that does not require you to quietly stop doing the things that make your life feel like yours. A house that gives you joy on the day you close and still gives you room on the day the property tax bill comes. The bank's number is a permission slip. Your number is a strategy.

TRY THIS

Take your pre-approval number and ask what you would have to give up at that monthly. If the answer is too much, the right number is lower. Write down the monthly that leaves your life intact, and shop to that.

03

QUESTION THREE · THE RESERVES

How much cash do you need to keep after closing, *not just for the down payment*?

WHY IT MATTERS

The conversation about cash usually focuses entirely on the down payment. How much do I need to put down. How much can I scrape together. The goal becomes maximizing the down payment to lower the monthly. That logic is fine until you realize that an empty bank account on day one is one of the most stressful ways to start homeownership.

The number that matters is what is left over after the down payment, the closing costs, the inspection, the moving expenses, and the inevitable first-month surprises. A water heater that fails the week you move in. A locksmith. A pest control visit. A bigger utility bill than you expected. The first-time buyers who feel calm in their first year are the ones who closed with reserves still in place. The right down payment is the largest one that still leaves you with enough cushion to feel safe.

TRY THIS

Decide your post-closing cash floor before you decide your down payment. A few months of full new monthly expenses is a starting point, not a stretch goal.

04

QUESTION FOUR · THE OFFER

How do you write a competitive offer in Greater Boston *without losing your discipline*?

WHY IT MATTERS

Greater Boston is a competitive market, especially at the price points first-time buyers shop in. Multiple offers are common. Waived contingencies are common. Escalation clauses are common. The pressure to outbid, waive inspection, waive financing contingency, or stretch on price feels like it is the only way to win. Sometimes it is. Often it is the way first-time buyers quietly overpay and quietly take on risk they did not fully understand.

Discipline is what separates the buyers who win the right houses from the buyers who win the wrong houses at the wrong prices. The right offer is the one you would still feel good about on Monday morning, not the one you wrote at 9 pm on a Sunday because you were tired of losing. There is a version of competitive in Boston that does not require waiving every protection. Knowing the line you will not cross before you walk into a bidding war is how you stay on the right side of it.

TRY THIS

Before you write your first offer, decide three things in writing. The price ceiling. The contingencies you will not waive under any circumstances. The conditions under which you will walk. Bring those decisions to every offer.

05

QUESTION FIVE · THE EXIT

If life changes in a few years and you need to sell, *what does this house do*?

WHY IT MATTERS

Most first-time buyers assume they will live in their first home for a long time. Some do. Many do not. Jobs change. Relationships change. Families change. Cities change. The five year holding period everyone quotes as the safe one is an average that hides a lot of people who sold in two or three for reasons they could not have predicted. A first home that does not resell well in a hurry is a real problem if life moves faster than the plan.

Buy a first home the next buyer will also want. A floor plan that works for more than one buyer profile. A location that holds value across a few different demand cycles. A condo board that has its act together. A building that has the major work the next inspector will look for already done or honestly disclosed. The exit lives inside the buy. The first-time buyers who feel calm a few years in are the ones whose first home would sell cleanly if it ever needed to.

TRY THIS

Walk a house you are considering and ask which three other types of buyer would also want it. If you cannot name three, that is a flag worth sitting with.

READY WHEN YOU ARE

Want to walk through these *before you start looking?*

These are not the only questions worth asking before you buy your first home. They are the ones I have watched separate the first-time buyers who feel calm and confident from the ones who learn the lessons the expensive way. If you want to walk through them on your specific situation with me, that is what a strategy session is for. No commitment to buy.

Book my strategy session

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